

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS

THE SPINE, v2.0.7 • RULED 2026-09-14

2026-09-12 (written overnight 11 to 12 September). The full document, all parts, rebuilt from v1.4 (with amendments v1.5 to v1.8) under the trusting-forgery premise and the three foundations Stephen ruled on 2026-09-11 (four-keys-foundations-2026-09-11.md). Every surviving ruling of the six delta rounds (v0.3 to v0.8) is written in as a row, not referenced. Part G is the canon annex an adversary needs. Part H is the only thing Fable may be told. No prose. Ruled by Stephen on 2026-09-14; premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 are superseded.

The premise in one paragraph. A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. She had changed her lock and told only the four, each alone, where the new spare lived, and it had happened again after, so she knew what the arithmetic said, and she wrote down that she would rather be imagining it. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her, who also wrote one kind line about himself that only one person alive can know is false.

The three foundations (Stephen, 2026-09-11), which bind every row below. (1) The van money is modest, on no paper Violet ever signed (thinly papered only by Margo's note of a conversation), written off by the sister's solicitor on Day 55 as unprovable against the debtor's account, and the occasion for Day 0, never the motive. (2) Violet dies because she is the one person who would know he had somewhere to go (restated by Stephen on 2026-09-13): alive, she knows a hidden self was built at her bench for ten months, whether he claims the panel or not; she forgets nobody and has the trade's ear; she is the one person who would never believe his drowning. The mark itself is two initials with no face and is dangerous to nobody but her. She has locked the panel in a store that opens only on her death, and her death also opens it. (3) After the second shelf she takes the key in and tells nobody, and she does not watch, because a phone on the shelf would tell her which.

Status: RULED THE SPINE OF THE EPISODE (Stephen, 2026-09-14), superseding premise v8.1 and spine v1.4. Attacked six times in full (Fable four rounds, GPT two); the device was never broken; every machinery finding was answered from the world or paid as a row. Two character locks remain, flagged as the things the reader tests must pass and that no adversary round can settle: Violet will not watch (C1), and Margo keeps a stateable hypothesis for ten days (C5). The four adversaries' final positions and the reasoning for closing the loop: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-disposition-r2-2026-09-13.md. Stephen: "We now need to get the story into the game. Only then can you tell if it really works. A lot of the story telling will be in the phrasing."

v2.0.1, 2026-09-13 (folded at Stephen's instruction). The slip-telling delta from the mobile session (four-keys-spine-v2.0-delta-the-slip-telling-2026-09-13.md): Violet tells the four the new pot each alone, over three days, in their own places; Ruby's telling at her car is owned as residue (R20). The Sunday fixed: the lock and the locksmith move from Day -36 (a Sunday) to Monday -35; the tellings run -35 to -33; the probe (-30) and the key taken in (-29) stand. The three foundations' text says "the day after" the tin for the lock; read "the next working day".

v2.0.2, 2026-09-13 (Fable round 1 answered; all rows, no rulings). The loft over the racks is the whole row's (A1 -380, -75; D1; G), and Violet does that sum and it closes on nobody; she shows Brad last out of pride, paid (A1 -70). The kind line is repaid not forgiven by calculation, because a forgiven debt is still an estate's claim (C2 Week 3). The box lie has its reason (A2 17:30). The barrel went to the sister sealed and logged by weight; the room's answer to where she put it is written (A2 Day 5; A3 Day 33). She fitted the cylinder herself (A1 -35; A3 Day 15). Margo's Day 8 position is written and paid (A2 Day 8; C5). Chapter 7 airs only what Ally can source; the boat owner stays unaired (A5 Day 311). Foundation 1's unenforceable read as written off. Review: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-fable-r1-2026-09-13.md.

v2.0.3, 2026-09-13 (Fable round 2, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, answered; all rows). The -75 sum written as the refusal it is (two hands can write this alphabet; she writes the other sentence), paid as Day -29 is paid. Violet tells Brad at the store door that the four get the keys if anything happens to her (A1 -19; row 16a; C2), which is the route foundation 2 lacked. The box lie owned as the one act against his interest, and the tell (A2 17:30; C2 verdict; F2). Meeting 4 written: Ruby's marathon line and its cost; Day 62 says why nobody says voluntary. Row 30 carries the key taken in. The barrel's count asked, given and computed to nothing (A3 Day 45; 33d; F13); the Civic Row account demoted (not yet due); Margo's arrival owned as the moment the reading acquires cost, standing on the book alone; the -120 list is Margo's own note, not Violet's hand. Ally's false sentence replaced by the on-air ask; the postmark and the box lobby stated. The solicitor holds an instruction and no fear; his Day 6 route computed and empty (C1 -3; row 16; C8; A2 Day 12). Review: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-fable-r2-2026-09-13.md.

v2.0.4, 2026-09-13 (Fable round 3, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, answered; all rows). The book: nobody but Violet, Brad and Margo ever knew it existed, written upstairs at night, fetched for the first time on Day 0 (G; row 20; Day 62). One copy of the letter, by decision, paid (A1 -19; C1 -3). Telling Brad at the store door as the third refusal, on the Day -600 fact (A1 -19). The will raised and deferred. The box lie as a costed mistake: Liam's "mine only came tonight", matched (A2 17:30; C2 verdict; F2); Ruby sits with hers and rings Liam at five. The panel wrapped, one carry; the tube never leaves the store (A2; D2). The date: mid August to the end of November, the December hearing. The forgery's first incident (the yard gate) gives "again" its antecedent (D3; row 30; Day 26); a bland Margo item so the list has one on each. Margo's fourth route, Ruby alone, computed and paid by her withdrawal from Ruby (C5); her Day 45 omission of the letter owned as her second. The barrel baseline wording. Two survivors, not three; the counter clerk and the overnight sort (A5 Day 311; row 62; G); the envelopes posted Friday evening. The skipper never knew of the bag. The boat owner's front-page route computed. Review: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-fable-r3-2026-09-13.md.

v2.0.5, 2026-09-13 (GPT round answered; six rows, all accepted by Stephen). The pot inside the yard, behind the wall and the latched gate, said by Liam on Day 15: told, overheard or watched, every route runs through the five (A1 -35; A3 Day 15). The panel's record is the four who saw it; nothing behind the door is reachable while she lives; telling Brad tells him nothing the three will not hear (A1 -19). The Day 14 risk of keeping the panel was nil and the Day 325 risk had a room and a face (C2 Week 3). Margo's Day 8: a private loan, not a gift, and no personal representative to receive it until Day 40 (A2 Day 8; C5). Chapter 7's tell carried down from Day 14: a claim about arrival, false, sourced (A5 Day 311). The tobacco binned as the first refusal, paid (A1 -37; C1 -6). Review and disposition: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-chatgpt-2026-09-13.md, episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-disposition-2026-09-13.md.

v2.0.6, 2026-09-13 (Fable round 4 answered; foundation 2 restated by Stephen). Why Violet dies: not the mark, which is initials with no face and dangerous to nobody but her, but Violet herself, the one person who knows a hidden self was built at her bench and who would never believe his drowning (header; graph; C2 -6, -3, -16; D1; D4). Brad's refusal to claim the panel written as his own lock and paid. The telling

at the store door as trusting him against the yours she has just heard, and his answer pencilled into the letter before it is locked. The will deferred for a reason. The café asks Brad at the wake and he closes it. Margo believes the book mislaid until Day 50. Chapter 7's tell made a checkable sentence ("nothing in the box this morning, must have come in the afternoon sort") against one sort a day. The landlady's reason to listen. The skipper away for the season. R16 defined; late July; Day 62 and C4 reconciled. Review: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-fable-r4-2026-09-13.md.

v2.0.7, 2026-09-14 (GPT round 2 answered; RULED). Day 15 written as the room's choice, not its proof, and paid. Brad's mirroring habit, the pet of the room, as the trait behind the box lie (A5 Day 276; C2 verdict; D3). C5 Week 8 restored to v1.4's honesty: the route to Del is open and computed and she does not take it. Chapter 7's claim said as the question it is. C1 names the distinction between measures that protect and the one that tells. Review: episode-1-spine-four-keys-v2.0-attack-chatgpt-r2-2026-09-13.md; disposition r2.

History. v1.0 to v1.4 (August 30 to 31): three ChatGPT rounds, passed on Margo's lock. v1.5 the store (September 3). v1.6 the tin (September 5). v1.7 the same night (September 7). v1.8 terminology (September 8). Six delta rounds on the trusting forgery (September 8 to 11), device never broken, machinery reworked each round; the churn diagnosed and the foundations ruled on September 11. This document replaces the deltas.

Terminology (v1.8). The container Violet keeps her cash in is the cookie barrel ("biscuit barrel" in AU player copy, flagged). "The tin" is the tobacco tin under the stairs and nothing else. "The store" is her brick boat store at the slip boatsheds; the four call it "the cupboard".

Decided (carried from v1.4 and the rounds): the motive and the occasion (Part D4) · the store (a brick boat store at the slip boatsheds, steel door, shrouded hasp, closed-shackle marine padlock) · the meeting room (Ruby's kitchen) · the cliff (Kestrel Head) · the source of Violet's money (her mother's cash, told only to Margo) · the span (Day 0 to Day 333, Brad's first preparation at Day -1500) · which survivor comes to Ally (Ruby first, Liam by episode four) · neither survivor is anything to Ally already · the object beside the forged letter (her mother's ashes) · intestacy (the sister administers with her own solicitor and accountant) · chapter 7 is a suspect turn on the box number, not a proof of forgery.

THE GRAPH, IN ONE TABLE

The whole truth, once. Known in full only to Brad.

What actually happened	Day
A deckhand who lives aboard his skipper's boat drinks at Brad's flat and keeps a dry bag there. No family. After a night's drinking Brad walks him to Kestrel Head and pushes him. The body is never found. The skipper reports him; the file names the boat as his address and never names Brad. Low risk, no sample (R16). The bag, with his papers, is Brad's.	-1500 to -1090
Brad builds the exit on the dead man's genuine name and puts his own face on nothing. A room paid in cash 400 miles away, a workshop paid in cash, a prepaid, a PO box in Havenbay for the business.	-900 to -400
He hollows the trade: cash where offered, declared turnover falling.	-850 onward
He makes the panel on Tuesday nights at Violet's bench after she has gone: her alphabet, better than hers, signed with the monogram of the initials he will live under. He keeps it wrapped in the roof space over her paint racks, because his flat and his van must stay clean and because that loft runs the length of the row of units behind the fish market, is boarded from every unit and the market's own store, and is entered by nobody.	-380 to -80

What actually happened	Day
Violet tells Margo she is calling in what she is owed, for the lawyer in the fight with her sister. She tells Brad on Day –110, in mid August, with a date: the end of November, for the solicitor's account before the December hearing; and what she will do on the first if it has not come: have Margo write the loan up properly.	–120, –110
A roof leak. Violet finds the wrapped panel. She carries it round the trade for a month asking whose hand. Brad hears from the café on Day –40.	–75 to –40
The tin. Brad doses her hidden tobacco with a concentrate from the shelf above (Day –38, a Friday); she catches the stain on the Saturday evening, does not light it, bins the tobacco, and on the Monday changes her front door lock, has one new spare cut, puts it in the second pot under the step inside the yard, behind the wall and the latched gate, and, over the three days after, tells the four, each alone.	–38 to –33
Brad, with the new spare while she swims, turns her mother's tube on the back-bedroom shelf to face the door: a probe, to see whether she tells the four. She does not. She takes the key in the next morning and tells nobody.	–30, –29
The morning of Day –19, in her book with times: four keys cut on Lantern Street at nine, the packet's two off the end of the slip; the panel, the letter and her mother into the store and the padlock on at ten, Brad watching, shown the panel last; four envelopes lodged at Civic Row before noon. From that hour Brad knows the store opens only on her death, and that the one mind that would never believe his drowning is the one asking whose hand.	–19
Brad tries the pot on Day –9 and finds it empty. He does not enter. He knows she has closed the house and told nobody.	–9
Brad walks to Mariner's Row about the money on the last Monday before the month's end. She pours two glasses and goes up for the book. The stairs. He waits twenty minutes, takes the book, rinses his glass, leaves by the back door, lifted and pulled so it catches.	0
Accident. Liam breaks a pane to reach her. The four keys. Brad clears his box at seven on Day 14, reads her store at 07:20, takes the true letter and the panel to his own locker, conforms his draft at his own bench, and by two the forgery and her mother are in her store. The four open it together that night. The panel leaves in a bag for the ridge wall on Day 46 and with him on Day 60.	1 to 60
He contacts Margo from a cash prepaid on the channel she uses for Tessa, walks 19 miles in from the inland halt on Day 214, and pushes her from the point.	180 to 215
Ally arrives after the front page. Her listeners find the pieces. The panel is described on air on Day 325 and is gone from his wall by Day 326. His landlady writes that night. The reference sample taken to identify his body identifies him alive.	266 to 333

A. THE CLOCK

Day 0 is the Monday Violet dies. Negative days precede it. Weeks in Part C: Week 1 = Days 0 to 6.

A1. Before

Day	Event	Who knows
–2000	Violet sets Brad up: a second-hand van and his first stock, in cash from the barrel, on no paper. She asks Margo whether a loan needs paper; Margo says yes; Violet does not. It is not a secret: all four know Vi set him up.	The four; Margo advised
–1500	Violet's mother dies; Liam drives them in the last night. Violet clears the house first and takes the cash her mother kept. The sister does not know. The ashes come home in the crematorium's scatter tube and go on the shelf in the back bedroom. The sister asks once, after the funeral, about the ashes; Violet says she will take her out to the point; the sister assumes it is done and does not come to the house again.	Violet; Liam knows the night, not the cash; the four have seen the tube on its shelf
–1450	Violet asks Margo whether cash from her mother is taxable. Margo notes it in her own file.	Violet, Margo

Day	Event	Who knows
-1200	The sister moves to sell the house. The dispute begins. Violet instructs a solicitor on Civic Row. Violet has made no will and keeps meaning to.	Violet, sister, solicitor, later all four
-1800 →	Brad practises Violet's cursive on Tuesday nights at her bench from her job notes, and burns the sheets.	Brad
-1500 → -1090	The deckhand; the cliff; the skipper's report; no sample (R16). Brad's name nowhere on the file. The skipper never knew where the man kept his papers ("somewhere ashore"); the constable notes papers not aboard and asks no further, per R16.	Brad; the skipper; HCPD file
-900 → -400	The exit on the dead man's name, Brad's face on nothing. A PO box in Havenbay for the business, the number on the van; leaf and size come by post to the box. A room 400 miles away, cash, quarterly, as a lodger. Weekend absences begin.	Brad; the landlady knows a lodger under the other name
-850 →	Cash where offered; the pub landlord pays cash from Day -700. Declared turnover falls.	Brad; the pub; Margo sees the pub's side
-600	Violet notices Margo has a Sunday and a green app. She says so to Brad, the only one she talks to about the other three.	Violet, Brad
-380 → -80	The panel, Tuesday nights at Violet's bench after she leaves, kept wrapped in the roof space over the racks: a loft the length of the row of units behind the fish market, boarded from every unit and from the market's store, used by nobody. Signed with the monogram he lives under now.	Brad
-250	Brad runs a marathon in another city and tells the four it was a wedding. Ruby sees the results page on Day -200 and says nothing.	Brad; Ruby
-200	In the crane cab Brad asks Liam what the yard would give for the van, cash, spring maybe.	Brad, Liam
-120	Violet tells Margo she is calling in what she is owed, for the lawyer, and names Brad and the sum. Margo's file note of the conversation, in Margo's own hand, dated. Nothing in Violet's hand exists about the loan but the book.	Violet, Margo
-110	Violet tells Brad, in mid August: by the end of November, for the solicitor's account before the December hearing; and on the first of December, if not, she will have Margo write it up properly. Brad decides to go early, by the death he has prepared. He has not yet decided she dies.	Violet, Brad
-100	Violet says at the café, in passing, that she is calling in what she is owed. No name.	Café owner
-75	The leak. A ceiling board comes down and the panel with it. Two sums are available to her and she writes one. Where it lay: the loft's the whole row's; half the market could have put it up there. Whose hand: two people on this coast can write this alphabet, and she is one. She writes the first sentence in order not to write the second, and it is the same refusal she makes on Day -29 with the key: she would rather not know which. Paid at the same price.	Violet
-70 → -40	Violet shows the panel to the cinema owner, the café, two other signwriters: whose hand is this. Two say yours, in a very good year; one asks whether she has shown her lad. She has not, and does not for five weeks, and the reason is hers and paid: it is her alphabet done better than she can do it, and he is her pupil; she will show him last, when she has an answer to hold against his. She never gets one.	Those four people
-45	Violet stumbles on the weed-covered slip walking backwards talking. Bruised; swims anyway. Ruby treats the bruising at Wharf Street and records a fall. Witnessed, innocent.	Violet, Ruby, the slip swimmers
-40	Brad hears from the café that she is carrying a gilded panel round asking whose hand. He knows what she has found.	Brad
-38	Brad, with the spare from the meter box while she swims, doses the tobacco tin under the stairs with a concentrate from the shelf above, caps the bottle, leaves the lid loose. Nothing brought into the house.	Brad

Day	Event	Who knows
-37	Rolling one in the evening, Violet sees a brown stain leach through the paper. She does not light it. Lid loose: could be her; bottle above capped; the dose is through the tin. She cannot be sure. She bins the tobacco, and the bin goes out on the Tuesday. Her book: I threw it out. If I'd kept it I'd have had to do something with it. The first of her refusals, and paid like the others: a kept sample is a decision to find out, and she would rather it was her own carelessness. She tells nobody. Nothing under the stairs looks wrong to anyone who does not know.	Violet
-35 → -33	Monday: she changes the front door lock herself, a new cylinder from the hardware shop; the locksmith on Lantern Street cuts one spare from the new key without ever seeing the house; it goes in the second pot by the yard door. She tells the four, each alone, the same sentence: I've moved the spare, it's under the second pot now. Liam in her kitchen on the Monday evening, come to check on her, who looks at the new cylinder and asks; she says the old one was sticking, with the fluency she lies about cigarettes with; Ruby on the Tuesday at Ruby's car at the top of the slip, Vi up from the water, the regulars still in; Margo across her own desk on the Tuesday; Brad at the workshop at midday on the Wednesday, door shut (midday, clear of his Tuesday-night practice, which needs her gone). She does not say why. The spare is for them; Liam has let himself in to check on her for twenty years.	Violet, the four, each alone
-30	Brad, with the new spare while she swims, turns the tube on the back-bedroom shelf to face the door. A probe: will she tell the four.	Brad
-29	She finds her mother facing the door. After the lock, five people knew the pot, and one is her. She takes the key in, onto her own ring, and tells nobody. Her book: I've taken the key in. If it stops, it was one of them or it was me. I would rather not know which. She does not watch: a phone on the shelf would tell her which.	Violet
-19, 09:00	Four keys cut at the locksmith on Lantern Street; his book records four copies, that date. The packet's two she drops off the end of the slip, and writes that down.	Violet, locksmith
-19, 10:00	At the sheds: the panel under her arm, the letter, her mother. One copy of the letter and no other, by decision: a copy in a solicitor's file is a document her sister's people can demand on intestacy, and she will not have her sister read it; and the four read it together or not at all, and one copy behind one door is the form of that. The panel's record already exists in four people who saw it and can describe it, which is the record Ally later uses. Nothing behind the door can be reached by anyone while she lives. Brad is there for his own locker. She shows him the panel, last of all: whose hand. He looks at it a long time and says yours, and names the R. She adds one line to the letter at the store door, in pencil, after he speaks (Brad says it's mine), then locks the three things into her store and puts the new padlock on in front of him, and when he asks about the new lock she tells him, lightly, the thing she is about to arrange: if anything happens to me, you four get the keys, and my sister gets a padlock. She lied to Liam about the cylinder and will joke to the solicitor about her sister, and she tells Brad the truth, because he is the only one of the four she has ever talked to about the other three (Day -600), and because to keep it from him would be to let him be the second hand. She has just watched him look at a panel she did not make and say yours, and she knows it is not hers, so she has just watched him be wrong or lie about the hand. Telling him about the keys in the next breath is her choosing to trust him against what she has just seen. That is the refusal in its exact form, specific to him and to that minute, and it is paid at the price of everything after. Then she writes his answer into the letter before she locks it: Brad says it's mine. From that hour he knows she has locked his name in a place that opens only on her death, and that the door will open to four people, one of them him, at his box.	Violet, Brad
-19, before noon	Four sealed envelopes lodged with the solicitor on Civic Row, addressed as she addresses them, Brad's to the box on his van: post these after my funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. He raises the will, as he has before; she says when the house is settled, not today, because a will made now is a document in the litigation and her sister's people would read it as the fight's next move. The keys were never in her house.	Violet, solicitor
-19, evening	Brad, with his workshop key, takes a sheet of her layout paper and her pen from the workshop.	Brad
-18 → -10	Nothing visible. Tuesday visits, the slip, the receipts bag. Brad drafts at his own bench from what he knows: the store, the four keys, his box, and what she has been noticing, which she told him herself when she showed him the panel.	
-9	Brad tries the second pot while she is at the slip. Empty. He does not enter. She has closed the house and told nobody.	Brad
-8 → -1	Nothing visible.	

A2. The death and the keys

Day	Time	Event
o Mon	21:30	Brad walks to Mariner's Row, phone left at his flat. She lets him in. The money: November ends on Thursday. She pours two glasses.
o	21:55	She goes up for the book to show him the figure. He follows. The landing, the light off. One push.
o	22:20	She stops breathing at the foot of the stairs. He has not touched her again. He takes the book. He rinses his glass and puts it on the rack; hers stays on the side.
o	22:30	Out by the back door, lifted and pulled so it catches. The neighbour at N ^o 14 sees a man's back in the lane, a coat, hands empty, and thinks nothing. The book is under the coat.
1 Tue	06:00	Ruby's text, then Ruby's car at the slip. No Violet.
1	12:30	Liam at the workshop. Shut.
1	13:10	Liam at the house. The second pot: no key. He goes round to the yard, sees her through the kitchen window, breaks the pane by the back door, lifts and pulls it, finds her. 13:14 he rings it in.
1	14:00	Uniform, then the Harbor Ward sergeant (Del) at a sudden death: unwitnessed, head injury, foot of the stairs, front locked, back latched until the fender broke a pane, no disturbance, one glass of wine on the side. Coroner's officer informed. Door-knock: N ^o 14 saw her Monday morning, and a man's back in the lane about half ten, a dark coat, hands empty. Noted: unidentified male, lane, approx 22:30. Nothing to identify him against. The four are asked on Day 2 whether any of them called on Monday night; all say no.
2		Liam into the workshop, heater off, finds the barrel. Rings the sister. Ruby reads Violet's record at the surgery: the slip fall.
3		Post-mortem (Cortez): skull fracture and brain injury consistent with a fall down a domestic stair; healing bruising consistent with the recorded slip fall; blood alcohol modest.
5		The sister arrives. Liam hands her the barrel in front of Ruby and Margo, sealed as HCPD sealed it on Day 2 and logged by weight, never counted in front of anyone; Margo's four-year-old figure for it (row 2) has been spent down since by a lawyer and a life, and she knows it. She takes Violet's keys from the police. No will: she administers as next of kin, with her own solicitor and her own accountant. She does not know the shelf and does not look for it.
6		Coroner opens and adjourns. Body released.
8		Margo helps the sister with paperwork: hands over Violet's business books and says the private loan book is not among them. Shrug. Nobody else knew it existed. Margo's position, held since Day -2000 and written here so it is paid: a private loan Violet refused to paper against her advice, told in confidence, is not a receivable of the business, and her own note of the late-July conversation is a note she was never instructed to act on. On Day 8 there is nobody with authority to receive it: the sister is next of kin with the house keys, not the administrator until letters of administration about Day 40, and a professional gives a dead client's private affairs to the personal representative once appointed, not to a relative in a kitchen. Nobody with authority asks Margo anything until Day 45, and when asked she answers in full. In the room she says nothing about the book for a plainer reason: until Day 50 she believes it mislaid in the sister's clearance, a notebook in one of forty boxes, and a notebook is not odd. The book becomes a fact to her only when Brad's answer to the estate meets it on Day 50. The cost is hers: an accountant putting a dead friend's privacy above the estate's books for thirty-seven days in which nobody asked.
11 Fri		Funeral. The wake photograph: the four together. The café owner, who is Brad's café and nobody else's of the four, asks Brad at the wake the question she would ask the lad: did Vi ever find out whose hand that gold board was. Brad: hers, an old job she'd forgotten she'd done; she was embarrassed. The café owner is satisfied and never raises it again until Ally asks on Day 283. The cinema owner and the two signwriters are not the four's people and are asked nothing by anyone until Ally. Brad knew this route existed from Day -40 and closes it here, in one sentence, at a wake.
11 Fri, evening		After the funeral the solicitor posts four envelopes as instructed, after the day's last collection, so they carry the Saturday postmark; a slip in each lists the four addressees, one a box number.
14 Mon	07:00	Brad clears his box, as every morning. The bare note: if you've got this I'm dead; go to my store at the boatsheds; the padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones; go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. He reads it standing in the post office.

Day	Time	Event
14	07:20	Brad at the slip boatsheds, van on the slip road; no camera; his own locker in the same corridor is his reason to be there. Opens her store with his key. Reads her true letter. Takes it and the panel, wrapped as she wrapped it, to his own locker in one carry; the tube stays where she put it. A boat owner antifouling before the tide, whose boat Violet lettered and whose tender Brad painted, says early for you, and sees which door he was at, and a flat parcel carried between two doors.
14	07:45 to 10:00	At his own bench: the draft, made since Day –19, conformed to her true letter. Her paper, her pen.
14	14:00	The forgery into her store, beside her mother, who never left it. Padlock on.
14	17:30 onward	Ruby, off nights, wakes at three and reads hers at about half past, and sits with it, because the note says together and she does not know what together means yet; she rings Liam at five when the crane stops. Liam reads his at half five at the yard; Margo at six. Liam rings Brad at a quarter to six with the sentence Brad has had fourteen days to prepare for and prepared: since seven, and I waited, because she said together. What Liam actually says is: have you seen yours yet, mine was in the yard post this afternoon. And Brad, matching the man on the line, says: same, nothing in the box this morning, it must have come in the afternoon sort. He hears it as he says it. There is no afternoon sort to the boxes, and he knows it, and he has just said it to a man who will remember it. It is the one thing he does that day that does not serve him, and it is not a reflex: it is a prepared line failing to a question asked in a form he had not prepared for, and he knows at once, and cannot take it back. The tell chapter 7 turns on. Nobody will sleep on it.
14	21:00	The four open the store together, torches. A letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot.
14	22:00	Read at Ruby's kitchen table. Relief, then the shame of relief, then the lock: she changed her lock and told us, and it happened again after; nobody says the arithmetic aloud. Liam explains March and July the moment they are read. Ruby explains the nights: a roster. Ruby reads the kind line aloud and the room is glad of it. Ruby says the police line does not sound like Vi; Liam says why (Vi and the police, the night her mother died); Ruby lets it go. The slips, four addressees, Brad's the box on his van: nobody thinks about it. They decide the sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at. Weekly meetings, Saturdays from Day 19. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall.
14	23:00	Brad, home: the drafts, her true letter and the book into his own grate.

A3. The room

Day	Event
15	The outward look, one evening at Ruby's. Liam: front locked, back latched, no key in the pot, one glass. Number 14 at the funeral: a man's back going out the back at half ten. The back door, which Liam rehung in spring on the same visit as the window catch, does not catch unless you lift it as you pull; the four have cursed it every Tuesday since; whoever left knew, or found out in ten seconds; a narrowing thing. Nobody else in her life: no cleaner, no lodger, no tradesman (she fitted the cylinder herself; the locksmith cut from a key and never saw the house), a smart meter, a sister four years away. Then the pot itself, from the man who fitted the gate: the second pot sits under the step inside the yard, behind the high wall on the lane side and a gate that latches from inside; it cannot be seen from the lane, from N ^o 14 or from anywhere but inside her yard or her house, so whoever watched it was already in. They know what they cannot prove: a wall can be climbed, a gate can be followed through, a step can be searched by a stranger with time. Ruby says it and nobody argues. And then they choose, the way frightened people choose, and the spine says so: her sentence in her hand (told only you four), her death, the letter's list, a yard nobody watched, and nobody in her life to look at instead. The closing thing is hers, three sentences in order: she changed her lock and told us four; it happened again; she took the key in and said nothing, and it stopped. Nobody at that table looks outward after the third, not because they cannot, but because they will not, and the later chapters indict exactly that. It is the room's choice, written as one and paid. Nobody asks at the sheds: nobody suspects the letter.

Day	Event
19	Meeting 1. The lists, as she asked: who has been near each of them. Yard hands, a ward, clients, customers. Where she told each of them goes on each list: Liam in her kitchen, Margo across her desk, Brad at the workshop at midday with the door shut, three tellings alone and indoors; Ruby's at her car at the top of the slip, the two of them, the regulars still in the water and Ruby knows every one of them by name and by house, nobody within a sentence. Nobody who could have known a pot. Liam confirms the third of the yard; the letter has told one truth. Nobody lists money: the one money fact in the room is on Vi's own list and it is a kindness. Where were we on the Monday night: Ruby on shift; Margo at home, alone; Liam alone at the yard; Brad at home, on foot, alone. Nobody has an alibi and the quiet man has the least. Ruby: she thought she'd know, and she's dead. Nobody answers.
26	Meeting 2. Everything odd about Violet. The gate, the shelf, the lock, in her order, and why she did not say why. Margo reads the paragraph for what is missing and finds nothing missing: a gate, then a lock, then a shelf, then a key taken in. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch and the door, spring. Margo underlines Spring.
33	Meeting 3. March and July again, beside the catch, the pot and the back door. Liam, asked by Ruby: I wanted her off that shelf, that's the whole of it. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Liam, to Brad, once: where did you find the van money, all at once? Brad: a good year, and your tenders. Liam nods; it is true. Ruby: and where did she put it? In the barrel, where else; it went to the sister sealed. Nobody can check and nobody wants to. Nobody looks at the sideboard.
40	Meeting 4. The lists worked against each other. Brad defends Liam and loses, and Ruby, wanting his defence discounted, says the thing she has held since Day –200: you told us a wedding and it was a marathon; what else have you told us. Brad: I run. I didn't want the fuss. I'm sorry. The room takes it as vanity, not flight, for two reasons it holds: Vi's own hand has told them where to look, and a man who lies about running is not, to them, a man who lies about a key. Ruby's cost, paid: she has checked up on a friend and said so in front of him, and she is smaller for it, and she does not raise the crane-cab question she does not know Liam holds. Liam holds it and does not raise it, because Brad is his only defender.
45	The sister's accountant rings Margo about the missing loan book. She tells him everything she knows about the money and nothing about a letter: the private book existed and is missing; the van loan to Brad was on no paper, against her advice; Violet told her in late July she meant to call it in for the hearing; she has no record of any repayment. She does not say that a letter in the deceased's hand states repayment: that is the room's decision of Day 14, and it is her second professional omission beside Day 8, owned and paid in the same currency. Margo asks the one question an accountant asks: what cash was found. He tells her the barrel's count. It exceeds the van sum, and against a baseline four years stale and spent down by a lawyer and a life, it distinguishes nothing: repaid or unpaid, the number is what it is. Computed; produces nothing. He mentions the Civic Row account outstanding; she knows it was not yet due, and it tells her nothing either.
46	Brad places the bag at the ridge wall: clothes, cash, the panel wrapped, on a customer run. Ready since Day 30.
47	Meeting 5. It lands on Liam, without one line of the letter having said it. Margo, alone at the sideboard while Ruby is upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back.
48	The sister's accountant writes to Brad.
49	Brad rings him: Vi helped him out years ago; it was settled between them; nothing in writing either way.
50	The accountant rings Margo back: Mr Collins says settled; any record at all? Her book would have it, and it is gone. Margo's arrival, owned as what it is: not a new fact but the moment the reading acquires a cost and a shape. Her unease has been there since Day 14, small and explained away. Now the room has landed on Liam (Day 47), and she has just certified to a professional, on her own word and his, the one sentence in the letter nobody can check, about the one man whose record left a locked house the night Violet died. The letter's one kindness and Brad's answer to the estate are the same sentence. That is the reading, and it stands on one leg: the book.
51 to 53	The sums at three in the morning. The one person who kept the room on Liam by defending him. It is a reading, not a proof, and there is nowhere to take a reading.
54	Meeting 6. Margo stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Ruby asks. "I've said what I think." Ruby lets it go. Brad notices, and is the only one who can read it.
55	The sister's solicitor advises: an unpapered cash loan, the deceased's record gone, the debtor's account given; nothing to claim. Written off.
60 Fri 22:40	Van to the Kestrel Head car park. 23:12 one message to the group thread: I can't do this any more. I'm sorry. Phone on the seat. The watch, smashed, thrown to the rocks. 23:30 the coast path inland, then the ridge path.
61 Sat 05:47	First train from the inland halt, cash single. 15:00 at the lodgings, a job that ran late.

Day	Event
61 06:30	A dog walker finds the van. Police. Del. Coastguard search Days 61 to 63. Flat searched: passport, cards, tools, laptop, all present.
62	Watch found at the base. Reference sample from the flat. Missing person, high risk, presumed in the water. Interviews Days 62 to 63: Ruby, Liam, Margo, each says grief. None mentions the letters. The marathon and the crane-cab question sit in two heads as a young man ashamed of wanting more, not as a man who left: the watch is on the rocks and the message on the seat, and he was the one who defended Liam until it broke him. Nobody says voluntary. Nobody mentions a book, because two of the three never knew there was one.
64 →	The three keep meeting. Ruby drives it.
77	Margo to Tessa on the app: the thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that. Tessa screenshots it.
82	Ruby decides the sister should have her mother back. She tells her Violet had locked her in her store at the sheds, and hands her the tube. The sister has the store's padlock cut the same week. Empty.
91	Brad's rent stops.
96	It lands. Ruby says it to Liam's face. Liam leaves and does not come back.
117	The landlord clears the flat. Boxes to Ruby.
97 → 213	Liam and Ruby do not speak. Margo withdraws from Ruby. Margo drives to Tessa every second Sunday.

A4. The stranger, the return, the second death

Day	Event
180	A new contact on the green app, from a number that leads nowhere: you're the one who stopped believing the letter. Brad has her number from the group and knew the app from Violet.
180 → 212	He knows the wording of the message, the watch, the time on the car park clock. He says Brad was not alone that night. Everything points her away from Brad and towards the woman who ran every meeting. Everything deletes. Margo does not turn: she keeps arriving at the man who defended Liam.
212 Wed	Friday. The point. Eleven. I'll show you where he went down and you'll see it isn't what they said.
213 Thu	Brad tells the landlady a job away Friday to Saturday. Train south, cash, two changes.
214 Fri 17:10	The last train reaches the inland halt. He walks the ridge path, 19 miles.
214 22:50	Margo's car in the Kestrel Head car park, ten minutes early.
214 23:00	The point. He asks to see what he sent her. She hands him the phone. She goes over at 23:10. Her phone and his prepaid into deep water at 23:20.
215 Sat 05:47	The first train. A cash single, wet boots; a woman on the platform notices.
215 06:40	The dog walker finds the car. Police. Search.
215 09:30	Officers at her address: the "in case" card, Tessa's number.
215 15:00	Tessa is rung and drives down.
215	Del pulls Brad's file beside it.
218	Margo's body in the harbour. PM: injuries explained by the fall and the water.
219 → 221	Del interviews Liam and Ruby. Each, separately, frightened, hands over the letters: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her.
222	Formal statements. Three deaths, five letters, two survivors. The detective division takes it with Del attached.

Day	Event
225	Margo's carrier records.
230 → 250	The store letter examined against the four notes and her workshop paper: consistent with known samples, same paper stock.
235	Solicitor confirms lodging on Day -19 and four addressees, one a box number.
240	App provider: nothing. Tessa re-interviewed: the line about the cupboard; read as doubt about the reading.
245	Coroner's officer asked to look again at Violet: no new evidence of an act; finding stands.
262	No further action. Both survivors informed.
263	Ruby talks to the Gazette.
265	Front page: the four friends of Violet Moore, the wake photograph.

A5. Ally

Day	Ep	Event
266		Ally reads it. Del: we looked. Properly. There's nothing.
269	1	Ally has the paper, Ruby's willingness, and Del's nothing.
276	2	Ruby: the room, the letters read out, the boxes, Brad's habits: keys on the table moved twice, thank you like it cost him, up at five to run, and the one everybody knew, that he agreed with whoever had spoken last, the pet of the room for seven years; the one line that didn't sound like Vi, and that she let it go. Ruby will not say what stood beside the letter.
283	3	The café and the cinema owner: she was calling money in; and she was carrying a gold panel round asking whose hand it was. The sister, bitterly: her mother's ashes, kept from her four years, locked in a shed, handed back in the tenth week by a friend who would not say why. The download map shows a listener in a town 400 miles away from this week.
290	4	Liam talks. The boat owner rings the Tip Line: the young one was at her store at twenty past seven that Monday morning, hours before the four of them came at night, carrying a flat parcel between two doors. Ally gives it to Del and does not air it.
297	5	Ally asks: did Margo say anything to anyone.
300		Tessa writes, with the screenshot.
304	6	The words go on air: the thing in the cupboard is wrong. Two signwriters write in about the panel.
311	7	The box number. What airs is only what Ally can source: Ruby's envelope, the solicitor's slip listing four addressees, one a box, and the Saturday postmark; the two survivors' own accounts of when they read theirs (Ruby at half past three after a night shift; Liam at half five at the yard) and Margo's at six by Ruby's memory of her own call to her, said as that; Liam's account of his call to Brad at a quarter to six, on the record: Liam said his was in the yard post that afternoon, and Brad said nothing in the box this morning, must have come in the afternoon sort; the habit both survivors knew, that Brad cleared his box at seven every morning; and the counter clerk, on the record, that there is one sort to the boxes a day, overnight, in the boxes before the lobby opens at seven, and no afternoon sort has ever existed. Ally's claim on air, no more, and said as the question it is: he told Liam that evening that his letter had not been in his box that morning and must have come in an afternoon sort; the counter says there has never been an afternoon sort, and both survivors say he cleared his box at seven every working morning. So either the one sort missed his box on that one day, or he had it at seven and said he had not. She does not say which. Then the ask she has used before: if you saw Brad Collins anywhere that Monday morning, write to me, not to anyone else. The boat owner's sighting stays with Del, unaired; it is why Ally believes what she airs, and she never says it. The café's line about money is aired without a name, because it had none; that the letter's one kindness is about that money is Ally's inference, said as inference. Why the listener believes it: the panel the town saw her carry and the letter never mentions; the one line that did not sound like Vi; a kindness to exactly one man. Not proof, and Ally says so.
311		The skipper writes: the deckhand who used to drink at Brad the signwriter's went missing three years before Violet. To Del, never aired. Del revives the file on Day 312.
318	8	The platform woman writes: the first train, wet boots, cash. To Del, not on air.

Day	Ep	Event
325	9	The panel described: black ground, twenty-six gold capitals and an ampersand, a crack across one corner, a small mark bottom right that was not her name and not his.
325 night		Brad takes it off the wall and burns it.
326		The landlady, who has listened since Day 283 because the front page was picked up nationally on Day 267 and she is a true-crime listener who found the show from it, and because her lodger has it playing through the wall, dusts his room on a Tuesday. Gone. She writes to Ally that night.
327		Ally to Del, 07:00. Del to the other force.
333		Arrest on the identity offences. Prints against the Day 62 reference. Brad Collins, alive.

B. THE ACCESS LEDGER

One row per fact. Columns: fact · who holds it · from when · by what route · who they could lawfully tell · the recipient's earliest competent action on that fact alone.

B1. Facts that exist before Day 0

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
1	Violet holds cash in the cookie barrel, more than painting explains	Violet, Margo, Brad, Liam from Day 2	Day -1500	Her act; Margo told for tax; Brad saw the barrel	Anyone; Margo owes confidence	None: cash is lawful
2	The cash came from her mother's house	Violet, Margo	Day -1450	Margo's file note	Margo: nobody	None
3	Violet set Brad up, van and stock, cash, no paper	The four	Day -2000	Common knowledge among them	Anyone	None: a gift or a loan between friends
4	She is calling the van money in this autumn, for the hearing, by the month's end	Violet, Margo (her own dated note of the conversation), Brad; the café knows she was calling money in, no name	Day -120 / -110 / -100	Told	Margo: her client's affairs; Brad: nobody	None; the note is Margo's hand, not Violet's, and is a record of what she was told
4a	What she will do on the first if it has not come: have Margo write it up	Violet, Brad	Day -110	Told	Nobody	The date Brad cannot let pass
5	Liam owns a third of the yard	Liam, Violet, Brad	Day -2900; Brad from -500	Violet told Brad	Anyone	None

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
5a	Her mother's ashes stand on the back-bedroom shelf, facing the window	The four (seen through four years); the sister believes them scattered	Day -1500	Sight	Anyone	None
5b	None of the four had been inside her house between Day -19 and Day 0	Brad	Day 0	Her life with them happened at the workshop and the slip	Nobody	The tube's absence from the shelf cannot be dated by any of the four
6	Margo has a partner two hours up the coast and an app	Margo, Tessa; Violet; Brad from Violet	Day -4000; -600; -500	Observation	Anyone	None
7	Brad's declared turnover is falling while the van stays busy	Brad; the pub landlord; Margo (the pub's books)	Day -700	Margo does the pub's accounts	Margo: confidential	None
8	Brad told the four a wedding; it was a marathon	Brad; Ruby	Day -250 / -200	A patient's son showed Ruby	Anyone	None. Not in the forgery: he would never salt with his own lie
9	Brad asked Liam what the yard would give for the van	Brad, Liam	Day -200	Direct	Anyone	None
10	Brad has a room, a name, and papers 400 miles away	Brad; the landlady knows a lodger under the other name	Day -400	His own act	The landlady: anyone; she has nothing to say	None
10a	A deckhand went missing from his skipper's boat three years before Violet	HCPD (a low-risk MP file, last address the boat, no mention of Brad); the skipper	Day -1090	The skipper's report; harbour master and pub enquiries	Anyone	None then. On Day 222 the proper look pulls everything on Brad and finds nothing, because the file does not carry his name. On Day 333 the name arrested 400 miles away is the name on this file, and the skipper is the man who can say where the deckhand used to drink
10b	The deckhand is dead, and how	Brad	Day -1100	His act	Nobody	None
10c	The deckhand drank at "Brad the signwriter's, the one with the van"	The skipper, from the deckhand's talk; never a surname, never an address	Day -1200	The deckhand said so	Anyone	Not asked in -1090: a low-risk report of an itinerant adult takes no list of drinking companions (R16). He connects the name when it is on air and writes to Ally on Day 311. Del revives the file on Day 312, runs the name: nothing since -1090 (row 10d). The link waits on her desk until Day 333
10d	No document anywhere carries Brad's face under the other name	Brad	Day -900	His design	Nobody	An activity check on the name, if ever run, returns nothing since Day -1090

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
10e	The prepaids, his and the one that spoke to Margo, were bought for cash with no registration	Brad	Day -500; Day 180	Havenbay prepaids are anonymous: settled at premise v8 as "a cash number" and "a number that leads nowhere"	Nobody	No provider ever sees a face or a name (round two, finding 9)
10f	The skipper kept a small box of the deckhand's things left aboard, photographs among them, in case anyone came asking	The skipper	Day -1090	The deckhand's oddments stayed on the boat; the papers were in the dry bag at Brad's	Anyone; nobody asks until Day 333	None. Added 2026-09-01 by Stephen's F1 notch ruling (structure v2.2); benign to every sweep row, since a bland photograph moves nothing until someone who can read it exists, and nobody in this episode can
11	A panel in her own alphabet, better than hers, with a mark, was hidden in her roof	Violet; the café, the cinema, two signwriters; Brad from Day -19 (shown), and from Day -40 (told)	Day -75 onward	The leak; she carried it round; she showed him last	Anyone	The trade: none, it is a panel; three of them said yours. Brad: see C2
12	Violet is asking round the trade whose hand	Café, cinema, two signwriters; Brad from the café	Day -70 to -40	Direct	Anyone	Brad: the tin
13	Her tobacco was dosed through with a concentrate from the shelf above; lid loose, bottle capped	Violet	Day -37	Her inspection	Police, if she chose	Contamination beside garden chemicals in her own cupboard; no offence; no suspect; advise
14	Violet stumbled on the slip and was treated for bruising	Ruby (clinical), Violet, swimmers	Day -45	Surgery	Ruby: nobody outside care	None. Innocent; witnessed
15	Four keys cut to one new padlock on Day -19; the packet's two in the harbour	Locksmith (four copies, the date); Violet's book	Day -19	His book	Anyone asking	None
16	Four sealed envelopes lodged before noon on Day -19, one addressed to a box number	Solicitor	Day -19	Instruction	Nobody: client confidence, contents unknown; she told him nothing but the instruction	On death, post them, with a slip listing the addressees. Computed: he learns of the death by Day 6; he holds an instruction and no stated fear; he could mention the lodging to the coroner's officer, who would note it and change nothing, since a lodged envelope is not evidence of an act; he posts them after the funeral as instructed

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
16a	The four get the keys if anything happens to her; the sister gets a padlock	Violet; Brad, told at the store door on Day -19	Day -19	Her own sentence	Nobody	Brad: the plan (C2, Week -3)
17	Violet believes someone with her key has been in her house, or that she is imagining it; she does not believe it is any of the four	Violet only; the book; the true letter	Day -37 to 0	Her inference	Police; the four; the solicitor	See C1
17a	She changed the lock on Day -35, told the four the new pot, each alone, over Days -35 to -33, and took the key in on Day -29 telling nobody	Violet; the four (the pot, not the taking-in); her book	Day -35 to -33, -29	Her acts	Anyone	Brad: an empty pot on Day -9
17b	Brad turned the tube on Day -30	Brad	Day -30	His act	Nobody	The fact the room later closes on has an author

B2. Facts created on Day 0 and by the death

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
18	Brad walked to and from Mariner's Row on Monday night	Brad; N ^o 14 saw a man's back, a coat, hands empty, going out the back	Day 0	Direct	N ^o 14: anyone	Told at the Day 1 door-knock; noted, unidentified male, approx 22:30; the four asked on Day 2, all say no. Told to Liam at the funeral. Re-read on Day 222 against Liam and going nowhere
19	Brad's phone was at his flat all evening	Carrier	Day 0	R8	Police on request	None without a suspect
20	Her book is gone	Brad; Margo, Day 8, at the handover	Day 0 / 8	Margo helped the sister with paperwork	Margo: the sister (told, shrug); the estate's accountant on Day 45 (told)	A book nobody but Violet, Brad and Margo knew existed (G): Margo because Violet told her the loan was written in it; Brad because he watched her go up for it. Ruby and Liam never heard of it, so on Day 15 and Day 26 the room has nothing to ask about. Paid as a world fact, not a convenience
21	Violet died of a head injury at the foot of her stairs, unwitnessed	HCPD, Cortez, coroner, the four, the sister	Day 1 to 3	Scene, PM	Public in outline	Coroner: accident (R19)
22	A fall six weeks earlier is on her GP record	Ruby, the PM	Day -45 / 3	Record	Supports the finding	None

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
23	Liam found her by breaking a pane at the back; the house was locked front and back; no spare in the pot	HCPD file; Liam	Day 1	Sudden-death report	Police; Liam: the four	Noted as forced entry by the finder. To the four on Day 15: she had taken the key in
23a	The house spare lived in the meter box for years, known to all four; moved to the second pot on Day -35 and told to each of the four alone over Days -35 to -33; taken in on Day -29 and told to nobody. Nobody holds a cut key to the house but Violet. Brad holds a cut key to the workshop	Violet, the four, Brad	Years; Days -35 to -33; -29	Her habit and her acts	Anyone	The room's pool-closer on Day 15
24	The barrel exists and went to the sister	The four, the sister, HCPD (property)	Day 2 to 5	Liam's honesty	Anyone	None
24a	No will; the sister administers with her own solicitor and accountant	Sister, her people; the four hear of it	Day 5	Next of kin	Anyone	The estate closes the books and the loan (rows 33a, 33b)
24b	One glass on the side; the rack	HCPD	Day 1	Scene		A woman who drank alone

B3. The letters and the store

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
25	Each of the four holds a bare note in her hand: go to my store together, these four keys are the only ones	The four	Day 14	Post	Anyone	Del, if handed it: statement; R22 examination (weeks; consistent); a dead woman's instruction about a store; no offence; nothing
26	Which store, and that it holds something	The four	Day 14	The note	Anyone	None
27	Brad was at her store door at 07:20 on Day 14, fourteen hours before the four, and carried a flat parcel between two doors	Brad; the boat owner (knew her door; read it as her pupil collecting her kit)	Day 14	Sight	Boat owner: anyone; nobody asks until Day 290	If anyone with a tampering hypothesis had asked at the sheds before Day 60, he would have named Brad. Nobody held one (R27)
28	What the true letter said: it isn't any of you and I'd know; someone with my key or my mind; the lock, the pot, the four, the key taken in; the tin; the panel and the three yours and I didn't make it; Mum; write down who has been near each of you; then the police, with something in your hands	Brad only	Day 14	He read it	Nobody	It is ash
29	The panel is in Brad's locker, then at the ridge wall, then on his wall	Brad	Day 14	Taken	Nobody	None

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
30	What the forged letter says: her frame kept (it isn't any of you; someone with my key or my mind; a bland first incident, the yard gate, in place of the tin; the lock, the pot and the four; and that she took the key in and it stopped); her reason for the scale (sixty and embarrassed); Mum, put here, the shelf the other week; her instruction with her reason (who has been near each of you); four bare facts (Liam's third; Liam's two requests; Ruby's nights; Margo not at the slip since the summer); the kind line (Brad paid me back the van money this autumn, every penny; the one thing this year that went right); the ban (not the police, over a shelf); read this together	The four; then Ruby's drawer	Day 14	The store	Anyone; the letter itself says not the police	Del, if handed it: as row 25; examination consistent; a dead woman who thought someone had been in her house and cleared her friends
31	The tube is her mother's; she put her there, they assume; nobody can say when the shelf emptied	The four	Day 14	Recognition	Anyone	None (row 5b)
32	Liam's third is confirmed in the room	The four	Day 19	Liam	Anyone	Lawful
33	The kind line is consistent with what Margo knows on the night (Vi was asking; he paid)	Margo	Day 14	Reading		Nothing to catch on Day 14
33a	The estate's inquiry: the missing book; the loan on no paper; Violet's intention to call it in; no record of repayment; Brad's oral "settled between us"	The sister's accountant, Margo, Brad	Day 45 to 50	Margo's answers; Brad's call	Sister's solicitor	Day 55: nothing to claim; written off
33b	The Civic Row solicitor's account for the hearing was outstanding at death, and not yet due (the month ended on the Thursday)	The estate's accountant; Margo from Day 45	Day 45	Settling the estate's debts	Anyone entitled	Nothing; not due is not unpaid
33d	The barrel's count, against the van sum and a four-year-old baseline	The estate's accountant; Margo, asked for on Day 45	Day 45	Counted by the estate	Margo: the room, Del	Distinguishes nothing; computed; the route produces nothing
33c	Margo's reading (Day 50): the letter's one kindness and Brad's answer to the estate are the same sentence; the only record that could test either left a locked house the night Violet died; the man it points at defends Liam	Margo only	Day 50	Rows 20, 30, 33a	The room; Del; the estate; Tessa	The room: how do you know, in front of him. Del: a letter in her hand later stamped hers, against a conversation in August and an unpaid bill; not evidence of an act (R19); no tampering hypothesis without an allegation, and the allegation is of murder on a reading. The estate: already told everything; closes. Tessa: the thing in the cupboard is wrong

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
34	Margo has stopped arguing with Brad	Brad	Day 54	Observation; he alone knows there is a lie to catch and who can catch it, and he has just been asked by the estate on her account	Nobody	Go

B4. The vanish

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
35	Brad's van, phone, message and watch are at Kestrel Head	HCPD (Del), the three, the dog walker	Day 61	Scene	Public in outline	Del: MP, search, sample, interviews (Ruling 2)
36	His flat holds his passport, cards, tools, laptop; his accounts are thin and untouched after Day 60	HCPD	Day 61	Search	Police	Consistent with the water
37	A reference sample and prints exist for Brad Collins	HCPD	Day 62	MP practice	Police	Retained (Ruling 2)
38	He walked the ridge path and took the 05:47	The halt's platform camera (R7, expires Day 85); the clerk	Day 61	Sight; tape	Anyone, if asked	Nobody asks: the MP is presumed in the sea
39	A bag was placed at the ridge wall on Day 46	Brad	Day 46	His act	Nobody	None; the wall is empty by Day 61
40	The three were meeting weekly over a letter from the dead woman	The three	Day 14 onward	Their own act	Del at interview Day 62	If told: Del reads the vanish as a grieving man. If shown the letter: a dead woman who cleared her friends and thought someone had been in her house; Del notes it on the closed file, cannot reopen a coroner's finding on it (R19). Either way, nothing moves
41	Brad's things are in boxes at Ruby's	Ruby, the landlord	Day 117	Clearance	Anyone	None; there is nothing in them
42	"The thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that."	Tessa (screenshot); Margo	Day 77	The app	Tessa: anyone; she does not know what cupboard	None until asked

B5. The stranger and the second death

#	Fact	Holder	From	Route	Could tell	Recipient's earliest action
43	A stranger on the green app knows things about Brad's death	Margo; Brad	Day 180	The app	Margo: Tessa, Del, Ruby, Liam. She tells nobody	If she told Del: a number that leads nowhere on a self-deleting app; nothing to pull; note. If she told Tessa: Tessa would tell her not to go
44	The meeting: Friday, the point, eleven	Margo, Brad	Day 212	The app	As 43	As 43
45	Brad was absent from the lodgings Friday to Saturday	The landlady	Day 213	Told a job	Anyone	None until Day 327
46	Brad rode the trains south and north on cash	Guards, the halt clerk, platform camera (R7, expires Day 246), a woman on the platform	Day 214, 215	Sight	Anyone if asked	Nobody asks: the death is an apparent suicide (Rulings 5, 7)
47	Brad's prepaid pinged the Kestrel Head cell at 22:50 on Day 214	Carrier	Day 214	Records, R8	Police on a tower request	A tower dump is not ordered for an apparent suicide (Ruling 5)
48	Margo's car, ten minutes early, and her body three days later	HCPD, the dog walker, her office, Tessa	Day 215, 218	Scene	Public	Del: search; Ruling 6 link; Ruling 7 camera; PM
49	Margo had a partner nobody knew	Tessa, HCPD	Day 215	The "in case" card in Margo's kitchen drawer; officers attending her address from the car's registration	Police	Statement the same afternoon; last movements
50	Margo's phone is not recovered	HCPD	Day 218	Search	Police	Carrier records (row 47's reach is the ruling)
51	Two survivors, five letters, three deaths	HCPD	Day 219 to 222	Del's own initiative and their fear	Police	The proper look: Days 222 to 262
52	The store letter is consistent with her known samples	HCPD	Day 250	Examination	Police; the survivors are told	Nothing to act on
53	The envelopes were lodged on Day -19, four addressees, one a box	Solicitor, HCPD	Day 235	Confirmation	Police	Her instruction predates her death; it does not name an act

B6. What Ally can reach, and from whom

#	Fact	Ally's source	Day	Lawful	Route into the episode
54	Everything public	Gazette front page	266	Yes	Ep 1
55	The letters, the room, the boxes, Brad's habits	Ruby, on record	270 onward	Yes: Ruby owns her letter and holds the store letter after its return from police	Ep 2
56	The debts being called in; the panel carried round; the ashes kept from her and handed back	Café owner, cinema owner, two signwriters; the sister	280 to 304	Yes	Ep 3, 6, 9
57	Brad at her store door at 07:20 on the Monday, hours before the four opened it, carrying a flat parcel between two doors	The boat owner at the slip sheds, Tip Line	290	Yes, caller consents	To Del. Not aired
58	Liam's side	Liam	288	Yes	Ep 4
59	The screenshot	Tessa	300	Yes: Tessa owns it	Ep 6, anonymised, with consent
60	The 05:47 and the boots	The platform woman	318	Yes	To Del. Ally asks on air for others
61	A persistent listener in one town 400 miles away	Her own download map	283 onward	Yes, her own data	To Del on Day 326 as corroboration. Never aired
62	The solicitor's slip listing four addressees, one a box, and the Saturday postmark; the two survivors' own accounts of when they read theirs and of the calls; the counter clerk's word that the overnight sort is in the boxes before seven	Ruby's envelope; Ruby, Liam; the post office counter, on the record as a general fact	276, 290, 305	Yes	Ep 7
63	The lodger, the wall, the gap	The landlady, private message	326	Yes	To Del at 07:00. Never aired
64	Anything in the police file	Del		No, and she never gets it. Del says looked, nothing	Ally's sourcing never depends on the file

B7. Residue

#	Residue	Where it sits	Who could find it	When it dies
R1	One dawn visit to her store on Day 14, his own locker in the corridor as cover; a flat parcel between two doors	The boat owner's memory	Anyone who asks at the sheds with a tampering hypothesis (R27); nobody does until Ally on Day 290	Memory does not die
R2	Her pen and paper used at his bench; drafts, the true letter and the book in his grate	Nothing survives; the pen goes back to the workshop on Day 15	Nobody	Day 14

#	Residue	Where it sits	Who could find it	When it dies
R3	A hand better than his public one	Only in the forged letter, which passes as hers	An examiner told to compare it against Brad's public work finds no match	Never tested
R3a	Nobody in the room ever saw Brad write cursive	Their memories	Ally airs it on Day 311	Never
R4	The bag at the ridge wall	Dry-stone wall, fourteen days	A walker between Day 46 and 60	Day 60
R5	The walk and the 05:47 on Day 61	Platform camera; the clerk	Anyone asking the halt	Tape Day 92; the clerk's memory fades
R6	The identity: a missing man's genuine name, with Brad's face on no document	The low-risk MP file in Del's own precinct, last address the boat; the deckhand's genuine passport and birth certificate in a drawer 400 miles away	The other force on Day 333 runs the arrested name and hits the file (Ruling 8). Nothing links the file to Brad before that day	Never
R6a	The skipper who reported him	His memory: the deckhand drank at Brad the signwriter's, the one with the van; a name he was never asked for	Ally's listeners; he writes in on Day 311. To Del, never aired	Memory
R6b	The deckhand's dry bag at Brad's flat, three years	Gone with the papers by Day -900; the flat search on Day 61 finds nothing of him	Nobody	Day -900
R7	Quarterly cash rent for over a year before he vanished	The landlady's rent book	Anyone who asks her, after Day 327	Never
R8	The prepaid's cell hits at Kestrel Head, Day 214	Carrier	A tower request (Ruling 5)	R8: seven years
R9	The trains, Days 213 to 215	Guards, clerk, platform camera; the woman on the platform	Anyone asking; the woman writes to Ally on Day 318	Tape Day 246
R10	Wet boots and a cash single at 05:40	The clerk, the woman	As R9	Memory
R11	Absence from the lodgings, Day 213 to 215, told as a job	The landlady	After Day 327	Never
R12	Ash in a workshop stove, Day 325	The stove	The other force, Day 333	Days
R13	A persistent download in one town from Day 283	Ally's analytics	Ally	Never
R14	The loan book	His grate, Day 14	Nobody	Day 14
R15	A man's back in the lane at 22:30, a coat, hands empty	Nº14; the file	Re-read on Day 222 against Liam	Permanent note
R16	Retired: no board, no hook, no rectangle			

#	Residue	Where it sits	Who could find it	When it dies
R17	An empty pot and a broken pane on Day 1	The file (forced entry by the finder); the four from Day 15	It says she had taken the key in; it dates nothing else	Permanent
R18	Brad's oral answer to the estate: settled between them, nothing in writing	The accountant's note	Ally never sees it; Del on Day 222 could, and reads a settled loan	File
R19	The tube turned on Day -30	Nowhere: a tube facing a door	Nobody	Day -29
R20	One sentence about a pot, said four times to four people alone, Days -35 to -33; once outdoors, at a car door at the top of the slip	The four's memory; the regulars' memory of who swam that Tuesday; nowhere on paper since her book burned	The room on Day 19, from the four lists. Ally, if she asks Ruby where Vi said it. Nobody asks the sheds who was about that morning; the room is listing people near the four, as she told them to, not places; a question at the sheds before Day 290 is R1	Memory. A canvass by recall, not a proof, and the document owns it. What closes the room is her sentence, examined and stamped hers: told only you four. She was the one person present all four times, and she chose the rooms

C. THE SWEEP

Authored order ignored. For each person, from the first day they can know anything: what they can lawfully know · the earliest competent action · the recipient · the recipient's earliest response · duties · outcome · named cost or lock. A suppression must be world-supplied or named as a character's, and paid.

Rule: an open route that reaches an authority and produces nothing is not a suppression. It is computed and written down.

C1. Violet (Day -120 to Day 0)

Week	What she can know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost
-11 to -7	A panel in her own alphabet, better than hers, in her roof	Ask the trade whose hand	Café, cinema, two signwriters	Yours, twice; have you shown your lad	None	Brad hears	She pays with the tin (Day -38)
-6	The tin	Report it with the tin; or keep the tobacco as a sample	Del; a drawer	Contamination beside garden chemicals in her own cupboard; no offence, no suspect; advise. A kept sample: nothing now, and after her death new evidence of an act (R19)	None	A record that she was frightened; the person who did it learns she knows. Or: a sample that would have reopened her death	Her choice, named and paid: she bins it, because a kept sample is a decision to find out. The same refusal as the sum, the key and the telling. Cost: the clean accident finding

Week	What she can know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost
-6	The tin	Change the lock; withdraw the old spare; cut one new one for the four; tell each alone	Locksmith; the four	Done, Days -35 to -33		The competent private measure, taken	None; and it is the measure that later closes the room
-5	The tube turned after the lock	Take the key in and tell nobody (done, Day -29). Or watch: a phone on the shelf				It stops	Her choice, named and paid: she will not watch, because watching tells her which, and the one thing she can bear less than being wrong about her own mind is being right about a friend. Every other measure she takes (the lock, the key taken in, the store, the four keys, the solicitor) protects without telling her which; the camera is the only one that tells her, and it is the only one she refuses. Cost: her life. This is one of the two things the reader test must pass
-4	The above	Tell one of the four	Any of the four	To tell is to accuse	None		To tell is to accuse. She writes it down for after instead
-3	Brad says yours, and watches her lock it in	Show nobody else; lodge the keys the same morning; make one copy of the letter and no other (a copy is a document the sister's people can demand; the four read it together or not at all)	Solicitor	He asks why; she jokes about her sister and tells him nothing else; he holds an instruction and no fear	None on sealed envelopes	Nothing to advise on	Consistent with the five; and the route from his office to Del on Day 6 is computed at row 16 and produces nothing, because he holds nothing but four envelopes

Verdict: PASS on a character choice that is the premise itself. Every competent private measure short of watching her friends is taken, and taken in the right order. The one she does not take is the one that would make her someone else.

C2. Brad (coherence with what he wants, not risk minimisation)

Week	Position	Action taken	Coherent because	Cheaper alternative rejected, and why
-157	He needs a name nobody will ever look for	Kill the deckhand for it	A bought name has a seller; a dead infant's record has a register; a man with no one, reported by a skipper and closed as drifted, is the only name with no file that watches it. The exit came first	Take the papers and let the man live: a living man reclaims a name the day he needs it
-16	The debt is called in, with a date and a consequence	Decide to go early, by the death he has prepared	The exit is built; the date is hers	Pay her: he could; the sum is modest against two years of cash, and paying it removes the date. He does not, because paying does not touch the panel, and from Day -40 the panel is the problem. Walk: a living Brad Collins with a debt to a woman who forgets nobody, written up by her accountant on the first of the month, is a man who is looked for into a cash economy Margo audits
-6 (Day -40)	She is carrying his panel round the trade asking whose hand	The tin: a poisoning that reads as cross-contamination	Deniable to the coroner; nothing brought into the house; one thing moved six inches. Her death now, while the panel is a curiosity in her hands, ends the question	Claim it ("mine, made at your bench, I wasn't ready to show you"): true, banal, and it hands the one person who forgets nobody the fact that he has built a hidden self, in her alphabet, for ten months, on her bench. A Violet who knows that is a Violet who reads his drowning as flight and asks the trade, the yard and the box until she finds where he went. The danger was never the mark; it was her knowing. His lock, in his own currency and paid: he cannot claim the panel because the one eye he cannot bear on the self he built to disappear in is hers, and that failure of nerve is the same one that later hangs it on a wall
-5	The tin failed; she changed her lock and told the four the pot	Nothing yet; the probe (Day -30)	He needs to know whether she has told them anything; the tube tells him she has not	Move now: he does not yet know where the panel is
-3 (Day -19)	She shows him the panel and locks it, in front of him, and tells him the four get the keys if anything happens to her (row 16a)	She dies, and the store opens to four people, one of them him. From that hour the plan is made: the stairs, the box at seven, the swap	The reason (foundation 2, as restated 2026-09-13): not the mark, which is initials with no face and dangerous to nobody but her, but her: alive, she knows the hand is one hand and has watched him call it hers; she forgets nobody; she is the one person who would never believe his drowning and would ask the trade, the yard and the box until she found him. Her death is the only thing that makes his believable to her. And her death opens the store and hands him the letter.	Fake his death without hers: the one mind that would read it as flight is alive and asking. Cut the lock: a cut lock is the one event that makes the police look
-1 (Day -9)	The pot is empty	Nothing. He knows she has closed the house and told nobody	The date is hers; he will be let in about the money	Break in: visibly wrong

Week	Position	Action taken	Coherent because	Cheaper alternative rejected, and why
1	The stairs	One push, twenty minutes, the book, his glass rinsed, the back door lifted and pulled, the lane	One impact; the phone at home; on foot; nothing visibly wrong	Finish her if she breathed: a second injury is the end of accident
1 to 2	The store, fourteen days	Wait for the post	No fifth key; the packet's keys in the harbour; no partition, roof or hinge; a cut lock makes the police look; his box gives him seven	Pick it: a skill he lacks and cannot practise on hers
3	The note in the box	Read the store at 07:20, his own locker as cover	The true letter says what she reasoned and the panel is there	Do nothing: four people pool who has been near them and read that she showed him last
3	The true letter read	Swap, do not empty; keep her trust and her instruction; salt with three true things; one kind line about himself: repaid, not forgiven	Empty tells four people someone came early; a letter that clears the four and points inward by choosing does weeks of work for him. The kind line kills the only motive in the room. Repaid, not forgiven, by calculation: a debt a dead woman let go in a letter is still a debt to her estate, a letter binds no administrator, and a sister who has litigated against her would have her solicitor write to him; a debt repaid is money gone and nothing to write about. And the truer reason: Margo heard Violet calling the money in hard in August, so forgiven is a louder lie to the one ear that matters than repaid is. He knows the cost: one person can catch repaid, and he knows who, and he watches her from that night	Forgive it in her voice: unfalsifiable by Margo but a live claim for the estate. Destroy the panel: the best thing he has made, and the mark is his; and on Day 14 the risk of keeping it is nil, because nobody alive can connect it to him (the four never saw it, the trade saw it as hers, and it will hang 400 miles away under a monogram that is his initials there). The risk acquires a room and a face on Day 325, when Ally describes it to a listener base that includes his landlady, and he burns it inside the hour: the same man, on two different days
3 to 7	The room	Defend Liam on she might have been wrong	An innocent surface; the reading returns harder each time	Accuse Liam: legible forwards
7 (Day 49)	The estate asks	Settled between us, nothing in writing, orally	Consistent with what the four read; admits nothing an estate can use	A written account: papers the loan
8 (Day 54)	Margo has gone quiet	Go now, by the plan ready since Day 30	He alone knows there is a lie to catch, who can catch it, and that the estate has just asked her	Kill Margo now: a second death in the group is a case
9 to 25	Missing, presumed	Nothing. Listen.	The least-cost move is stillness	
26 to 30	Margo has not spoken in five months	Contact her from a prepaid, on Violet's information	She is the one person who can think alive; he needs to know whether she has been turned, and he wants to be the one who turns her (the want the least-cost test does not score)	Stillness: she may speak any week and he will not know until it is too late
31	She will not turn	The meeting at the point	A woman who blamed herself for one man at that cliff dies at that cliff and everyone has the reason ready; and she must hand him the phone	Leave her: the one person who thinks alive is now certain there is a stranger who knows too much
39 to 47	Ally is airing it	Stay. Listen.	Leaving costs the built life and would confirm to someone nearby that they had seen something	

Week	Position	Action taken	Coherent because	Cheaper alternative rejected, and why
47	The panel described	Burn it that night; watch the house	Someone near him may have seen it; he cannot know who; the object must not exist	Run: as above
47	The landlady changes	Notice her, as Margo	Too late: she wrote the night she looked	

Verdict: every action is coherent from inside except one, and the document says so: the lie about the box on the evening of Day 14 is a prepared line failing to an unprepared question (Liam's "mine was in the yard post this afternoon", answered with "nothing in the box this morning, must have come in the afternoon sort"), and the failure is his oldest habit, known to all four and listed by Ruby in chapter 2: he agrees with whoever spoke last. Seven years the pet of the room, mirroring under pressure; on the one evening it mattered, the habit spoke before the plan. Known as a mistake the moment it is made, and it is the tell. The reason he kills is the mark; the debt is the date; the grief is the shape his own death wears.

C3. Liam

Week	What he can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
1	He found her; no key in the pot; the barrel	Hand the barrel to the sister; tell the police how he got in	Sister; the file	Takes it; noted	None	Done	None
3	The bare note	Take it to Del	Del	Row 25: nothing	None	Nothing	He holds an instruction, not a fear
3 (Day 14)	The forged letter names his third and his two requests, and says it isn't any of them	Explain both at once; take the letter to Del	The room; Del	The room: heard. Del: row 30, examination, nothing	None	Nothing; his secret on a police file	Self-interest lock: the only document he owns points at him
5 (Day 33)	The kind line: eight years' money in one autumn	Ask where it came from	Brad, at the table	A good year, and your tenders	None	True; he nods	The question is asked and answered
6	Brad defends him, loses	As above					Holds
9	Brad is missing	Tell Del at interview: we were working her letters and they had begun to point at me	Del	Row 40	None	Nothing moves; the file now contains him	Holds
14	It lands on him	I am frightened of Ruby	Del	What has she done? Nothing. Note	None	Nothing	Holds: fear of the letter still exceeds fear of Ruby
14 to 30	Silence, estrangement	As above					Holds; nothing has changed
31	Margo dead at the same cliff	Go in	Del	The proper look		Days 222 to 262	The break point

Verdict: PASS.

C4. Ruby

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
-7	The slip stumble	Treat, record			Clinical: done		
1	Violet dead; the record	Nothing to act on			A breach she never mentions		
3 (Day 14)	The bare note; the forged letter; the police line does not sound like Vi	Say so; take both to Del	The room; Del	Liam: Vi and the police, the night her mother died. Del: rows 25, 30: a dead woman who cleared her friends and did not want the police over a shelf; examination; nothing	Professional duty tested: no living person named at risk; no duty	Nothing; Violet's instruction broken for nothing	She lets it go, and tells Ally she should not have
3 (Day 15)	The three sentences	Look outward first	The room	Nobody there		The pool closes on Violet's own facts	Competence, not its absence
5	Liam lands	Open route to Del renews	Del	Row 30; nothing	None	Nothing; Liam learns she went	Computed, does not deliver
8 (Day 54)	Margo goes quiet	Ask her	Margo	I've said what I think	None		The second thing she lets go
9	Brad missing	Tell Del about the letters (computed; not taken: A3 Day 62, none of the three mentions them)	Del	Row 40	None	Nothing	She reads the message as grief because she loves him
14	It lands on Liam	I am frightened of him	Del	What has he done? Nothing. Note	None	Nothing	Holds
16	The boxes	Nothing in them					
31	Margo dead	Go in	Del (already coming)	The proper look	Police duty	Days 222 to 262	Break point: fear of a person
38	No further action	Talk to the Gazette	Gazette	Front page		Ally	Her fear made public

Verdict: PASS, with the thin lock named as in v1.4.

C5. Margo

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
-17	Violet is calling the van money in	Nothing: lawful			Confidence		
2 (Day 8)	The loan book is not among the papers	Tell the sister (done); tell the estate's accountant (none exists until about Day 40); tell the room (not done: she believes it mislaid in the clearance until Day 50, and a mislaid notebook is not odd)	Sister	Shrug	None: a private loan that refused paper is not a business receivable; her note is a conversation, not an instruction; no personal representative exists to receive it until about Day 40	Nothing: a book nobody else knew existed, and nobody to tell who could act	Paid: her privacy-over-the-books choice, owned in A2 Day 8
3 (Day 14)	The kind line: he paid this autumn	Read it beside what she knows		Consistent: Vi was asking; he paid		Nothing to catch	A small surprise, explained away
3 (Day 19)	The lists	List the calling-in?	The room	No: the letter has covered the money in Vi's hand, and a kindness is not odd			
7 (Day 45)	The estate's accountant asks about the book	Tell him everything about the money, privately; nothing about a letter	Accountant	Writes to Brad	Professional: done in full	Nobody outside the room hears of a letter	

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
8 (Day 50)	Brad told the estate settled; no record; the barrel's count tells her nothing (asked, given, computed). Together with the letter's kind line and the book gone from a locked house, that is a stateable hypothesis: the letter may have been substituted, and by the one man it is kind to	(a) Say it in the room. (b) State the tampering hypothesis to Del. (c) Tell the estate the number is unverified (done). (d) Ruby, alone	(a) The room. (b) Del. (c) The estate. (d) Ruby	(a) How do you know, in front of him. (b) Open and computed, as v1.4 had it: Del takes the hypothesis; under R27 it licenses a canvass of the sheds; the boat owner names Brad at her door at 07:20 on Day 14 by about Day 55; Brad is interviewed, says he went to his own locker and could not help looking, which is not an offence; the room learns; Brad goes that week. The episode's second act is a different shape and Margo lives. (d) Ruby cannot hold a thing without saying it in the room; telling Ruby on Day 50 is telling Brad by Saturday; Margo's withdrawal from Ruby from Day 54 is the cost.	None	(b) is the route that would have saved her, and she does not take it	★ THE LOAD-BEARING LOCK, Days 50 to 60, hers and paid. She could go to Del and does not, for reasons that are hers: to state the hypothesis is to name the youngest of them as a forger and therefore as her friend's killer, on a reading; she has been wrong about people before, and Violet lied about cigarettes with total confidence; and the man it points at is the one arguing for the man the room has chosen. Paid: Day 60, Day 214. If a reader does not believe Margo would keep this for ten days rather than say it to a sergeant, the episode fails here and nowhere else, and that is the sentence the reader test must pass
8 (Day 54)		Stop arguing		Ruby asks; "I've said what I think"		Brad reads it, alone	
9	Brad is gone	Tell Del: I think he forged it	Del	Forgery allegation against a presumed-dead man on a closed case: statement, examination (consistent), the store's access asked about, nothing to charge and nobody to charge	None	Nothing, and she has said in public what she cannot live with	Guilt lock: she chooses she was wrong about him. Available to her because her certainty rests on a reading, and Violet lied about cigarettes with total confidence
11	Guilt	Tell Tessa	Tessa	Tessa: what cupboard? Margo does not explain	None	A screenshot	Eleven years of compartments

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Response	Duties	Outcome	Named cost / lock
14	It lands on Liam	Say the letter is wrong	The room	As Week 8 (a), with a dead man as the only alternative	None		Holds: the alternative is that she killed Brad
26 to 30	A stranger who knows	Tell Del; tell Tessa	Del: nothing to pull. Tessa: do not go	None		Holds: the stranger is the only person offering her the reading she can live in	
31	The meeting	Do not go					She goes ten minutes early

Verdict: PASS, on a named character lock, with the route she does not take open and computed, as v1.4 had it. If a reader does not believe Margo would keep a stateable hypothesis to herself for ten days rather than take it to a sergeant, the episode fails here and nowhere else.

C6. Tessa

Week	What she can lawfully know	Earliest competent action	Recipient	Recipient's earliest response	Duties	Outcome
11	A line about a cupboard	Ask	Margo	Does not explain	None	Screenshot kept
31	Rung by police at 15:00 on Day 215 from the card in Margo's drawer	Drive down; statement	Havenbay police	Last movements; she is on the file the afternoon the car is found	None	The partner nobody knew is found by the review inside nine hours, because Margo left a card
35	Re-interviewed	Give the line	Detective	Read as doubt about the reading; on file	None	Nothing
43	Ally asks	Write, with the screenshot	Ally	On air, anonymised		Ep 6

Verdict: PASS. Tessa acts on the first day every time. What she holds does not carry a who.

C7. Del and HCPD

Day	The file	Earliest competent action	Duties	Outcome	Why it stops there
1	Unwitnessed sudden death, head injury, stairs, house locked, forced entry by the finder, one glass	Scene, PM, coroner, door-knock	Sudden death	Accident (R19). N°14's man noted; the four asked on Day 2	Nothing at the scene says otherwise

Day	The file	Earliest competent action	Duties	Outcome	Why it stops there
61	MP at a known site, message, watch, eight weeks after his friend's death	Search, sample, flat, interviews	MP procedure (Ruling 2)	Missing, presumed	Nobody mentions letters; if they had, row 40
215	A second car from the same four at the same site	Link the files (Ruling 6); search; Tessa's statement	MP, then sudden death	Suicide pending PM	
218	Body, PM, phone absent	Last movements (Ruling 5); camera (Ruling 7); interview the surviving friends	Sudden-death procedure; a cluster	Del reaches Liam and Ruby on Day 219 before they reach her	Competent and on time
222 to 262	Five letters, three deaths	Examination; solicitor (four addressees, one a box); coroner's officer; app; carrier; everything on each of the four; the estate's file (a settled loan, written off)	All run	Consistent; lodged Day -19; no new evidence of an act; nothing on Brad beyond his own MP file and a settled loan	Nothing where they look, because nothing is there
226	The store	Visit (empty since Day 82); access; the market manager	Review of a document's finding place	Anyone with a key, any morning	R27: a canvass needs a tampering hypothesis; nobody alive holds one until Ally on Day 290
292	Ally's Day 290 tip: the boat owner saw Brad at her locker at six on the Monday morning. Del already holds Tessa's Day 240 line	Under R27 the two together are a tampering hypothesis. Del takes the boat owner's statement, re-reads the store letter's examination, runs Brad Collins for any activity since Day 60	A hypothesis on a closed file with a presumed-dead subject	Brad, presumed drowned, is the only known pre-opening visitor. No activity under his name. No charge possible, no reopening of Violet on a visit to a store (R19), nothing to tell the survivors that is evidence	Del holds "Brad may have swapped it" privately from Day 292. It reaches nobody: not Ally (the file), not Brad (nothing moves under his name). It is why she moves inside a day on Day 327
312	The skipper's letter via Ally: the deckhand who vanished three years before Violet drank at Brad Collins's	Revive the low-risk file; formal statement; run both names	R16: reassessment on changed facts	The deckhand's name has no activity since Day -1090; Brad's none since Day 60. Two men presumed lost, one flat, three years apart	The name is now live in the system. Any officer anywhere who runs it gets Havenbay. Nobody runs it until Day 333
327	A landlady's message via Ally	Other force, prints, arrest		Day 333	

Verdict: PASS.

C8. Everyone else

Person	Knows	Earliest action	Recipient	Response	Why nothing follows
The sister	The barrel; the house; no will; her own people; from Day 82 the ashes and the store	Administer; ask her own accountant to close the books	Her accountant	The loan written off Day 55	She does not know the shelf; she is told of the store on Day 82 by Ruby; she tells Ally about the ashes, bitterly, on Day 283

Person	Knows	Earliest action	Recipient	Response	Why nothing follows
The estate's accountant	The missing book; the unpapered loan; Brad's oral answer; the unpaid account	Ask Margo; write to Brad; advise the solicitor		Written off	An unpapered cash loan the debtor says is settled
The market manager	Forty bays let for cash to people who do not want questions asked; a dead tenant paid to next year	None			He asks nothing and assumes the friends will clear it; he has never heard of a sister
Solicitor	Four sealed envelopes, Day –19, one to a box; no stated fear	Post after funeral; confirm lodging to anyone entitled; on Day 6, could mention the lodging to the coroner's officer	Coroner's officer	Noted; a lodged envelope is not evidence of an act	Contents unknown; he was told nothing but the instruction; the route is computed and empty
Locksmith	Four keys, Day –19	None			Nobody asks until Ally
Nº14	A man's back, a coat, hands empty, out the back, 22:30	Tell the door-knock; tell Liam at the funeral	Officer; Liam	Noted; the room's fact	No description to test
Boat owner	Brad at her door at 07:20, a flat parcel between two doors	Reads the front page on Day 265 (the keys, the store, that night): could ring Del; rings the Tip Line on Day 290 instead, when Ally airs the place, because a man who saw a friend at a dead friend's store rings a podcast before he rings the police. Computed: Del on Day 266 produces the same nothing as Day 292 (presumed dead; no charge; R19)	Tip Line, Day 290	To Del	Her pupil collecting her kit
Café, cinema, two signwriters	A gold panel, whose hand; three said yours; she was calling money in	The café owner asks Brad at the wake (Day 11) and is answered; the others are asked nothing	Brad; then Ally, Day 283 onward	Hers, an old job	A panel; nobody reported one missing; the four are not the trade's people, except Brad, who closed it; the police review never reaches the trade
The skipper	His deckhand missed a sailing, Day –1090; drank at "Brad the signwriter's"	Report him missing. Day 62: he is on the northern charter season from Day 40 to Day 300 and reads no Havenbay paper; he hears the show in the autumn and writes on Day 311	Harbor Ward	Harbour master, the pub (not there that night), the boat; low risk; closed as drifted (R16). Drinking companions are not taken for a low-risk itinerant adult	An itinerant adult with no one. The skipper is never asked where the man drank, and has no reason to volunteer a first name. He connects it when Brad Collins, signwriter, is on air, and writes to Ally on Day 311; to Del, never aired

Person	Knows	Earliest action	Recipient	Response	Why nothing follows
The constable, Day -1090	A man living aboard, last seen going ashore	Record, canvass, classify	The file	Low risk	Correct on what was in front of him; no one to place him with Brad. The pub is removed as a holder: the drinking was at the flat
Pub landlord	Paid Brad cash for a year	None			Lawful
Landlord (flat)	Rent stopped	Clear, boxes to Ruby			
The halt clerk, the platform woman	Wet boots, cash, Day 215	None until asked	Ally, Day 318	To Del	A man with wet boots on a morning train
The landlady	A lodger under the other name; his absences; the panel on his wall until Day 325 and gone on Day 326; his habits, from six weeks of strangers on air	Two routes, both computed. Local police, Day 326: a constable attends, asks the lodger his name, gets the deckhand's, runs it, and hits the file Del revived on Day 312; arrest that day or the next, with a constable on her doorstep while Brad is in the house and before anyone in Havenbay knows. Ally, Day 326 night: Del at 07:00, the other force the same day, observation, arrest on Day 333, and she is never seen to have moved. She takes the second because Ally has said on every episode: write to me, not to him, and not to anyone near him; I will take it to the police here. v8 settled it: tips to Del and never on air	Ally, then Del, then the other force	Day 333	Her window is hours and she uses them. Either route ends in the same cell; the premise chose the one that keeps her alive
Ally	Everything in B6	Del first, every time	Del		Airing a name would tell him which town; she never has one to air

C9. Causal order check

Claimed cause	Date	Claimed effect	Date	Holds
The exit needs a name	-1100	The deckhand	-1100	Yes
The debt called in, with a date	-110	Brad decides to go early	-110	Yes
The panel found and shown round	-75 to -40	The tin	-38	Yes
The tin caught	-37	The lock, the pot, the four told each alone	-35 to -33	Yes
The probe	-30	The key taken in	-29	Yes
The panel locked in front of him	-19	The plan: she dies and the store opens	-19	Yes
The empty pot	-9	Nothing; the date is hers	0	Yes

Claimed cause	Date	Claimed effect	Date	Holds
The bare note in the box	14, 07:00	The store at 07:20	14	Yes
The three sentences	15	The pool closes	15	Yes
The estate's question	45 to 50	Margo's reading	50	Yes: a fact arrives (the unpaid account; Brad's answer)
Margo's silence noticed	54	The vanish	60	Yes; the bag on Day 46 under a plan ready since Day 30
Brad's vanish	60	Margo's guilt; the reading lands	61; 96	Yes
Contact	180	Meeting	214	Yes
Margo's death	214	Survivors go in	219	Yes
Front page	265	Ally	266	Yes
Panel aired	325	Panel burned; landlady looks	325 night; 326	Yes

Sweep verdict: PASS on two named character locks (Violet's refusal to watch; Margo's ten days), both written on the page, both paid.

D. THE OBJECTS

D1. X, what Violet hid: the panel

A gilded alphabet panel. Oak, about 30 by 40 centimetres, black ground, twenty-six capitals and an ampersand in water gilding, a crack across one corner, and a small maker's mark bottom right that is not a name: the monogram of the initials he lives under now. Made by Brad at Violet's bench on Tuesday nights over ten months, in her alphabet and better than hers, kept in the roof space over her racks because his flat and his van had to survive a search, and because that loft is the whole row's and nobody's.

Why she has to die (foundation 2, restated 2026-09-13). Not because of the mark, which is two initials with no face and is dangerous to nobody but her (constraint 6 is true). Because of her: she found a hidden self built at her bench, in her alphabet, over ten months; she knows the hand is one hand; she watched him call it hers; she forgets nobody and has the trade's ear. A living Violet is the one person who would never believe his drowning and would ask until she found where he went. Claiming the panel would confirm the hidden self to that mind; denying it leaves his work locked in a box she keeps asking about. Either way she has to be dead on the day he is. Her death also opens the store and hands him her letter.

Why it is damning to the three and not only to Brad. Of the four the letter is addressed to, exactly one gilds letters for a living, and Violet wrote that she never taught him leaf. Pooled with Ruby's marathon, Margo's pub books and Liam's crane-cab question, it names a man making a name for himself somewhere else. That is why the true letter had to go, and why the panel went with it.

#	Constraint (v8)	Panel	Brush (Fable's seed)
1	Unique physical object, cannot be posted or copied	Yes: hand-gilded, one crack, one mark	Yes

#	Constraint (v8)	Panel	Brush (Fable's seed)
2	Meaningless alone, damning beside what the four separately knew	Yes, as above	Fails: it is hers; nothing the four know makes it mean anything
3	Not the motive	Yes: the debt is the motive; the panel accelerates	Yes
4	Something Violet could plausibly have found	Yes: a leak, a ceiling board, a wrapped thing above her own racks	Fails: she made it; nothing was found
5	Something he wants	Yes: the best thing he has ever made, in the self he could not show, and she wrote that he could not have made it	Fails: he has no use for her brush
6	Innocuous in a stranger's house four hundred miles away	Yes: an alphabet thing on a lodger's wall; the mark is his own initials there	Yes, barely: an odd brush
7	Describable by Ally without holding it	Yes: she carried it round for a month asking whose hand; four people can describe it	Yes: from across the road

Verdict: the panel passes seven of seven. The brush passes four and fails 2, 4 and 5 as X. It also fails as the decoy (finding 1): she used it every day until she died, Liam saw it in her bucket on Day 2, and any decoy must be a thing none of the four can place after Day -19.

D2. The decoy: her mother's ashes

The crematorium scatter tube, four years on the back-bedroom shelf, facing the window. All four have seen it. The sister believes it scattered. Brad turned it on Day -30 as a probe; she wrote it down, took the key in, and put her mother in the store with the letter and the panel on Day -19. The tube never leaves the store: Brad takes the letter and the wrapped panel at 07:20 and puts the forgery beside her mother at two. Nobody but the four ever sees it there. Played through nine stations in `four-keys-locker-object-treatment-ashes-2026-09-08.md`; the mantel clock is on file as fallback.

What it does. It makes "someone has been in my house" physical and hers. It leans at Liam by the room's inference alone (his two requests; the last week with her mother; the bedroom). It gives the survivors a silence no reader questions. It gives Ally the sister in chapter 3. It never points at Brad, never raises money, never touches Tessa.

D3. The two store letters, as claims

Claim	Genuine (Day -19), read only by Brad	Forged (Day 14), read by the four
Who	It isn't any of you four, and I'd know	Kept verbatim
What	Someone with my key, or my mind; I cannot tell which; both frighten me	Kept verbatim
The first time	The tin (her account of it)	Cut, and replaced in her voice with a first incident that is bland and unfalsifiable: the yard gate she bolts every night was unbolted one morning in October and she could not swear she had bolted it. It gives "again" its antecedent and sends nobody anywhere
The arithmetic	I changed the lock and told only you four where the new spare lives, and it happened again after, so I know what that says, and I would rather be losing my mind	Kept verbatim: it is true and it closes the room on itself

Claim	Genuine (Day –19), read only by Brad	Forged (Day 14), read by the four
The tin	The stain, the lid, the bottle; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown it out	Cut: a poisoning sends a nurse to the police
The panel	Her alphabet done better than she can; a mark for a name; Brad says it's mine, everyone says it's mine, I didn't make it	Cut: it names a gilder
Mum	Facing the door; I've put her in here	Kept, with a paragraph: the shelf the other week; not staying for whoever it is to stand and look at
The scale		Added in her voice: sixty and embarrassed; if I'm wrong nobody needs to know
Instruction	Somebody got the place of my spare from one of you without your knowing, or watched one of you use it; write down who has been near each of you; read it together; then the police, with something in your hands	Kept to "read it together"; then the ban: not the police, I've nothing they'd act on, I won't have them in your lives over a shelf
Her own list	None	Added: Liam's third; Liam's two requests; Ruby's nights; Margo has not been to the slip since the summer (true; work; harmless, so that the list has something on each of the four); and the kind line about Brad
Mentions money	No	Once, kindly, about Brad: paid back this autumn, every penny
How it could be written		The book, taken on Day 0, is pages of her cursive; years of Tuesday-night practice; her pen and paper from the workshop on Day –19; his own bench
The tell outside the letter		Brad's habit of agreeing with whoever spoke last, listed by Ruby in chapter 2 among his habits; on Day 14 it produced the one checkable lie
Retrospective tells (chapter 7, a suspect turn)		The box cleared at seven against three read after work; the panel the town saw her carry, absent; the police line; the kindness to exactly one man, in the autumn the café says she was calling it in

D4. The motive and the occasion, stated once

The reason: Violet herself: the one person who knows he built a hidden self and who would never believe his drowning. The panel, locked in a store that opens only on her death, is where that knowledge lives. **The occasion:** the van money, called in for the lawyer, due at the month's end, with Margo writing it up on the first if it did not come; modest, unenforceable, and never the reason. **The shape:** her death is the grief his own will wear seven weeks later.

E. THE RULINGS

R19 to R26 as v1.4 (accident stands; high-risk MP with sample; declaration of death only by family with interest, after years; posthumous documents examined routinely; carrier yes, app nothing, no tower request without an offence; same site links files; one camera at the car park; the deckhand's genuine name). R27 (v1.2): a canvass of a document's finding place needs a tampering hypothesis. **R28 to R30 (2026-09-11, the three foundations):** the money's status; the mark as the reason; the key taken in and not watched. Also

ruled during the rounds and in force: the ashes as decoy (provisional, clock on file); intestacy; the store's construction and rent; one glass; the loan open, the calling-in private; keys cut, used and lodged in one morning; chapter 7 a suspect turn; Day 82 via Ruby.

F. PRE-FLIGHT: THE THIRTEEN OBJECTIONS (RE-RUN)

#	Objection	Answer	Result
1	Why was the decisive material not found at the time?	The panel left in a bag on Day 60; the true letter was ash on Day 14; the one fact that breaks the forgery is a reading only Margo could make and she made it ten days before he went. The scene, the PM, the search, the sample, the examination and the review all ran.	Pass
2	Does the antagonist act in his own interest at every point?	C2, with one named exception: the box lie on Day 14, a costed mistake against his interest, made under a question he had not prepared for, which is the tell.	Pass, exception owned
3	Would a real person do the small thing this needs?	Violet takes the key in and does not watch; Margo turns the label and turns it back; Ruby lets two lines go; Liam asks where the money came from and takes the answer; Tessa screenshots.	Pass
4	Is the motive one an ordinary reader accepts?	A man's new name on a board in a dead woman's locked store, and a woman still asking whose hand.	Pass, and it is the thing to test with readers
5	Is any discovery a coincidence wearing a coat?	The leak, upstream of everything. Everything else is found by asking.	Pass, leak flagged
6	Does a reader understand every word?	Store, panel, tube, barrel, tin, pot, box, cliff, train. Gilding needs one line.	Pass
7	Can a reader hold the cast?	Violet, then four names, then Del and Ally. Tessa, the sister and the landlady arrive one at a time and late. The solicitor, boat owner, clerk, café owner, skipper, market manager and the estate's accountant are functions with no names.	Pass
8	Is it clear what the crime is, immediately?	A woman died on her stairs and her four friends were sent keys; two are alive and afraid of each other.	Pass
9	Can Ally source everything she says?	B6.	Pass
10	Does anything break its own rules?	Tips to Del never on air.	Pass
11	If a route is claimed as the only one, find the second	Every route to Del is open and computed.	Pass
12	Is the stake real?	Three bodies, a man's freedom, a woman 400 miles away.	Pass
13	Does anything decisive rest on a small number?	One was found and computed: the barrel's count against the van sum. It distinguishes nothing (A3 Day 45, row 33d), and the document says why.	Pass
+	Person or mechanism?	A man who kept the one thing that proved who he was, because she said he could not have made it.	Person

G. CANON ANNEX FOR THE ADVERSARY

*Standing facts of the world, so that no omission reads as a hole. R16 (bible): an itinerant adult with no dependants reported missing is classified low risk; no reference sample is taken; the file is closed as drifted and can be revived on changed facts. Havenbay is a fictional coastal city. Prepays are anonymous (a cash number). The green app retains no content and no contacts. Police attend every unwitnessed death, photograph the scene, door-knock, inform the coroner's officer; a coroner records accident on a competent PM and a secure house; reopening needs new evidence of an act by a person (R19). Missing persons at a known site are high risk, presumed in the water; a reference sample is taken from the home and kept (R20). A material posthumous document is examined routinely before it is acted on (R22). A canvass of a document's finding place needs a tampering hypothesis (R27). The slip boatsheds: old brick boat stores and a corridor of lockers, let for cash by the market manager, worked from first light, no camera. Brad's PO box is his business address and is on his van; there is one sort to the boxes a day, overnight, in the boxes before the lobby opens at seven, no afternoon sort, and the counter will say so to anyone. Brad holds a key to Violet's workshop (behind the fish market) and has for years; he never held a key to her house. The workshop is one of a row of units under one continuous loft, boarded from every unit and from the market's store, entered by nobody; the panel lay above her racks, but the loft is the row's. The house spare's history is row 23a. Violet's book of everything: dated, timed, written upstairs at night, alone, and kept there. Nobody but Violet, Brad and Margo had ever seen it or heard of it before Day 0 (Margo because Violet told her the loan was written in it; Brad because he watched her go up for it): Liam's twenty years of letting himself in were downstairs and daytime; her friends knew she wrote things down and never saw where. The loans and the fears went in the same book precisely because nobody knew of it. On Day 0 she fetches it for Brad to show him a figure, the first time it has ever been fetched for anyone, and it is the last thing she does. The deckhand: rows 10 to 10f. The three foundations: four-keys-foundations-2026-09-11.md. The six delta rounds and their dispositions: four-keys-premise-delta-trusting-forgery-.**

H. WHAT FABLE MAY BE TOLD

The redacted brief for step 4. Paste this block and nothing else. It contains what Ally has on the day she starts and what the city knows. Nothing from Parts A to G.

Brief for the opening of Episode One, titled The Friends with Four Keys.

You wrote the five as people. They are canon. Here is what happened to them, as Havenbay knows it, and what Ally holds on the morning she decides to make the episode.

The public account. Violet Moore, 44, signwriter, died at the foot of her own stairs on a Monday night about nine months ago. Head injury. Police attended, there was a post-mortem, a coroner recorded an accident. She had four close friends: Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera, Brad Collins. Two weeks after she died, each of them got a key in the post with a note in her hand: go to my store at the boatsheds, together, all four of you, and read what's there together. They went that night, all four of them. Behind the door was a letter in her hand. It said someone had been getting into her house. It said it wasn't any of them. It said she might be imagining it. There was something of hers beside it. The survivors will not say what.

They worked the letter for weeks at Ruby's kitchen table. Within a month they were sure it was one of them. Seven weeks after the funeral Brad drove to Kestrel Head at night, left his phone on the seat with one message on it, and was never found. His watch was on the rocks. Police searched and stood down. Five months after that Margo Rivera's car was found in the same car park, ten minutes before eleven on the dashboard clock, and her body came into the harbour three days later. Police reviewed it and called it what it looked like. She had a partner two hours up the coast that none of them knew about.

Liam and Ruby each went to the police within the week. Not to accuse. To say: I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her. The police looked, properly, for six weeks: the letter was examined and is hers, the solicitor confirmed she lodged the keys three weeks before she died, the coroner's finding stands, nothing was found. No further action. Ruby talked to the Gazette. The front page has the four of them at the wake.

What Ally holds on day one. The paper. A sergeant she trusts saying: we looked, properly, there's nothing. Ruby willing to talk. Liam not, yet. A Tip Line that has had nothing on this. No relationship to either survivor.

What the opening must do. Get the death and the keys inside the first forty-five seconds. Land on two living people taking each other apart in public over a dead woman's letter that cleared them both, and a podcaster who was not there for any of it. Under 330 words. Ally asks on microphone before she records anyone. Nothing in her voice claims to know what the police could not find.

Do not invent: which of the four; what the thing beside the letter was; what the letter said beyond that it cleared them, said someone had been getting in, and said she might be imagining it; anything about where anyone is now; any procedure. If the opening needs a fact not in this brief, leave a gap and mark it. No em dashes.

End of brief. Everything above this line stays in this file.

PROMPT FOR THE ADVERSARIES (paste everything below this line into ChatGPT; Fable is given the file)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This is the full spine of the episode, rebuilt after six rounds of attack on a partial version; Part E lists the rulings in force and Part G the standing facts of the world. Your job is to break it, not to improve it. Read Parts A to G in full (Part H is a brief for a different writer; ignore it). Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A fact stated in Parts A to G is a fact of the world; an objection that contradicts one must say why the world's fact fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **Violet, Day -37 to Day -19.** She catches the tin, changes the lock, tells the four the pot, finds her mother turned, takes the key in, tells nobody, does not watch, then locks the panel away in front of the one person she taught. Find the competent act she does not take, and say whether it ends the episode.
2. **Brad, Day -19 to Day 14.** The reason is the mark; the date is hers; he waits fourteen days for the post. Find the act that serves him better than the one written, on any of those days.

3. **The room, Days 14 to 47.** Four competent adults close the pool on her three sentences and land on Liam. Find the line one of them says that the document has not answered, and who says it.
4. **Margo, Days 8 to 60.** She tells the estate everything about the money and nothing about a letter; the unpaid account arrives on Day 45; Brad's answer on Day 50; she stops arguing on Day 54. Find her earliest competent action that changes the outcome, and say what happens.
5. **Chapter 7.** A suspect turn on the box number and the boat owner. Find what Ally airs that she cannot source, or what a listener checks and finds wrong.
6. **The whole.** Take the spine as it stands and find the earliest competent action by any person, on any fact, that ends the episode before its time. If there is none, say so.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.